The US flotilla from Japan had been stopped several hundred miles north of the Spratlys and the US ships involved in the original melee of September 9. The Chinese then boarded the *Curtis Wilbur* early on the morning of September 21 and scuttled the *Bertholf*, transferring all US military personnel to Mischief Reef for internment. This was a total of 415 sailors and coast guard members, including several dozen seriously wounded.

The Battle of the Senkakus

On September 21–22, Japanese Coast Guard and Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force ships engaged with elements of the PLAN's East Sea Fleet and the People's Armed Forces Maritime Militia (PAFMM). Though PAFMM vessels had reached the Senkakus on September 14, the East Sea Fleet did not release ships to the mission until September 18, after making sure that the *Gerald Ford* had halted at the Batanes in the Bashi Channel. It was, in fact, the sailing away of several East Sea Fleet vessels toward the Senkakus that led the *Gerald Ford*'s escort vessels to continue south toward Santiago Island.

Japanese Coast Guard (JCG) ships had played cat and mouse with PAFMM ships since September 14 in the waters off the Senkakus, but with the arrival of the PLAN ships already on patrol in the East China Sea, the PAFMM vessels boldly moved within two miles or so of the islands. An interdiction by the Japanese turned into a skirmish, but the much heavier-armed PAFMM vessel sank one thousand-ton JCG cutter, with the loss of ten coast guard members. An emergency call was answered by JASDF F-2 fighters, which had been moved to Kadena specifically for antiship missions. The F-2s launched SAM-2 antiship missiles that disabled two PAFMM ships. Three hours later, fighters launched from the *Liaoning*, which had moved north from its position near the Babuyan Islands into the Bashi Channel between the Batanes and Taiwan. These J-15s successfully attacked four JCG cutters with standoff air-to-surface missiles, sinking or disabling them. With JMSDF ships en route to the Senkakus but not yet off station, the JCG